

# The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global Data (2023) • Source: Our World in Data / IHME

# **Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression**

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**1 in 3**

Women experience major depression in their lifetime

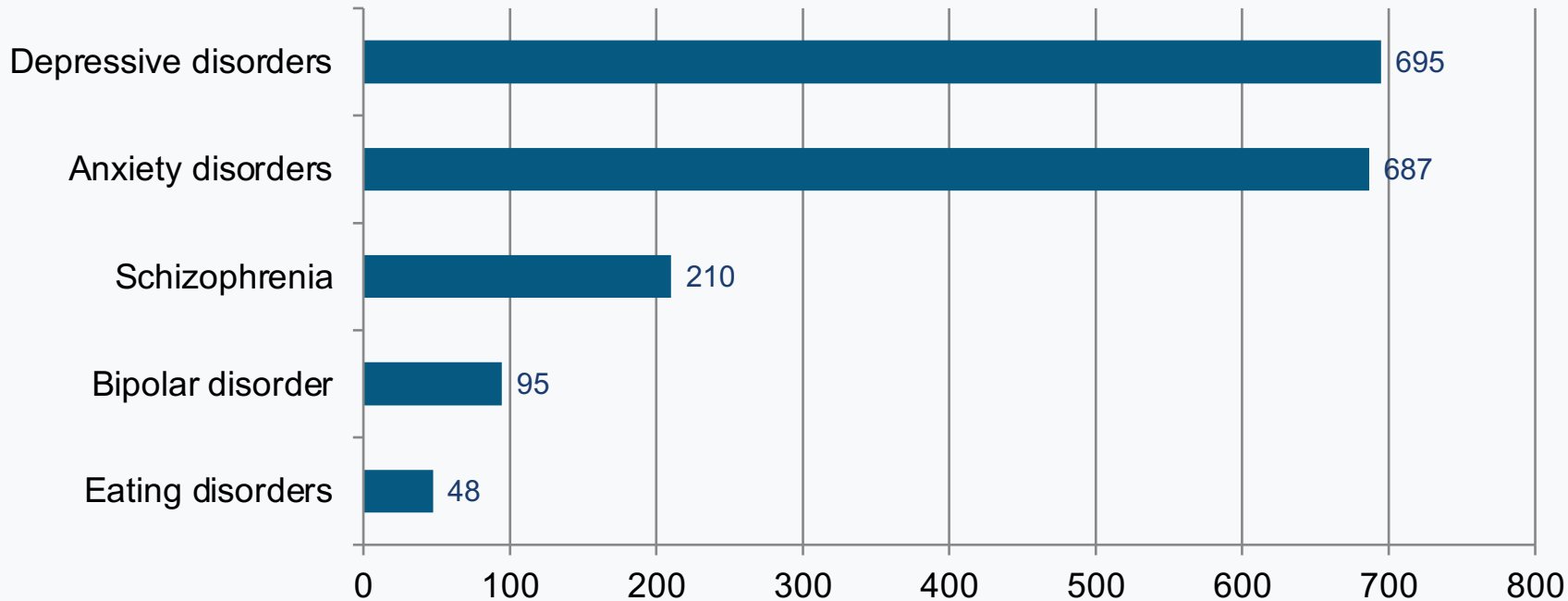
**1 in 5**

Men experience major depression in their lifetime

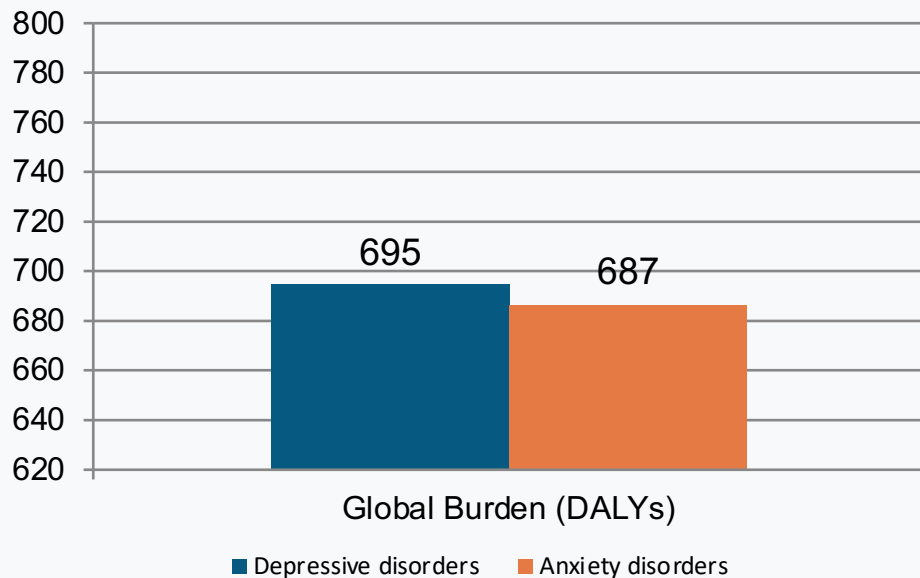
**Mental health conditions span from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar). Establishing prevalence is critical for policy.**

# Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K

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# Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



- Depressive disorders and anxiety disorders together dominate the global mental health burden.

Combined, they account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five major categories.

The near-parity in their DALY rates (~695 and ~687) highlights the massive dual challenge these common conditions present for

# Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Impact

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While affecting fewer people overall, severe mental illnesses carry a disproportionately high individual burden relative to their prevalence.

**Schizophrenia**

**210.2**  
**DALYs per 100k**

**Bipolar Disorder**

**94.6**  
**DALYs per 100k**

*The severity and disability associated with these conditions necessitate specialized, intensive care resources.*

# Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

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**Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced. Yet a profound gap persists between need and available care globally.**



## Stigma

Discomfort disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or community members keeps many from seeking help.



## Access Barriers

Treatment is often completely lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



## Quality of Care

Even where treatment services exist, the quality of care provided may be inadequate.



## Underreporting

Due to stigma and lack of access, estimating true prevalence is difficult; actual burden is likely higher.

# How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

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Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression. Effective policy interventions must account for these cultural, economic, and systemic differences.



## Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings



## Religious & Spiritual

Highly prevalent in many regions worldwide



## Talking to Family/Friends

A widely reported coping mechanism

# Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Care & Closing the Gap

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- **Depression and anxiety together** represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~80% of top 5 disorders).
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- **Schizophrenia and bipolar** carry disproportionate individual burden and require specialized clinical care networks.
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- **Treatment exists** but access and quality remain inadequate, especially in low- to middle-income areas.
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- **Stigma** actively suppresses both help-seeking behavior and the collection of accurate prevalence data.
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- **Policy should prioritize** scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while adapting to varied coping strategies and maintaining